WEEK 2 · LESSON 9 OF 24 · HANDOUT

Prompting Like a Pro

Study time: **about 50 minutes** (reading, video and activity)

▶ **Watch:** https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=jC4v5AS4RIM — open the lesson online to watch inside the course.

🎓 **Go deeper:** CS50 Tech Talk with OpenAI: ChatGPT for Writers — https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ZeTeHYHOtuw

Your goal in this lesson: Write clear prompts using the four-part formula (Role, Task, Context, Format) and improve weak prompts into strong ones.

A prompt is just clear instructions

Imagine giving instructions to a smart new intern who knows a lot but knows **nothing about you, your audience or your goal**. The clearer you are, the better the work. That is all prompting is.

A weak prompt: *"Write about marketing."*

A strong prompt: *"You are a marketing advisor for small businesses in Kigali. Write five low-cost ideas to attract more customers to a new coffee shop near a university. Give each idea a title and two sentences. Keep the language simple."*

The four-part prompt: R-T-C-F

Part	Question it answers	Example
Role	Who should the AI act as?	"You are an experienced HR officer…"
Task	What exactly should it do?	"…write a job advert for a receptionist…"
Context	What background does it need?	"…for a hotel in Musanze; candidates need English and French; salary is competitive…"
Format	How should the answer look?	"…in under 200 words, with a bullet list of requirements."

You do not always need all four, but adding **context** and **format** almost always improves the answer.

More ingredients that help

- **Audience** — "for parents", "for my manager", "for first-year students".
- **Tone** — friendly, formal, persuasive, neutral.
- **Length** — "in 3 bullet points", "about 150 words".
- **Constraints** — "use simple English", "do not use technical words", "use RWF for money".
- **Examples** — show one example of what you like (we go deeper in the next lesson).

Before and after

Weak prompt	Strong prompt
"Summarise this."	"Summarise this report for a busy manager in 5 bullet points, then list 2 decisions they need to make."
"Write an email to my teacher."	"Write a polite, short email to my lecturer asking for a 3-day extension on my assignment because I was sick. Keep it under 120 words."
"Give me business ideas."	"Give me 5 business ideas I could start in Huye with less than 500,000 RWF, aimed at university students. Put them in a table with cost, customers and main risk."

Common mistakes

- Asking for too many different things in one prompt.
- Forgetting to say who the audience is.
- Accepting the first answer without asking for improvements.
- Pasting private or confidential information.

Remember this: Give a role, a clear task, enough context and the format you want — then refine.

Name: _____ Date: _____

Activity

Task 1

Choose a real task from your study or work.

Task 2

Write a **weak** one-line prompt for it and save the answer.

Task 3

Rewrite it using **Role, Task, Context, Format** and save the new answer.

Task 4

Compare the two answers. List three ways the strong prompt improved the result. Keep your best prompt — you will add it to your prompt library in the Week 2 project.

Self-check

Think about your answers here, then take the quiz online — it is marked instantly and explains every answer.

1. What does R-T-C-F stand for in prompting?
   - A. Request, Test, Check, Fix
   - B. Rules, Text, Code, File
   - C. Read, Type, Copy, Finish
   - D. Role, Task, Context, Format
2. Which part of a prompt tells the AI how the answer should LOOK?
   - A. Format
   - B. Role
   - C. Context
   - D. Task
3. Which prompt is STRONGEST?
   - A. Make something nice.
   - B. As a tourism officer, write a 150-word welcome message for visitors to Lake Kivu, friendly tone, ending with 3 tips.
   - C. Tourism Rwanda.
   - D. Write about tourism.
4. Which addition almost always improves an AI answer?
   - A. Making the prompt as short as possible
   - B. Adding emojis
   - C. Using capital letters
   - D. Giving context and the desired format
5. What is a common prompting MISTAKE?
   - A. Setting a word limit
   - B. Naming the audience
   - C. Asking for improvements
   - D. Asking many unrelated things in one prompt
6. You get a decent first answer. What should you usually do next?
   - A. Close the app
   - B. Accept it immediately
   - C. Refine it by asking for specific changes
   - D. Ask a completely different question

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